ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Deontic and epistemic modality

Distinguish obligation, permission and prediction from inference, and resolve modal ambiguity through context and paraphrase. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use deontic and epistemic modality to show whether a modal concerns how the world is known or how people are required to act while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Distinguish obligation, permission and prediction from inference, and resolve modal ambiguity through context and paraphrase.

MODEL

The documents must remain confidential, and they must already be in the archive.

modal + proposition interpreted through source, time and agency

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main deontic and epistemic modality patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses show whether a modal concerns how the world is known or how people are required to act.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in policy, legal reasoning, analysis and nuanced conversation.

Build meaning before form

Distinguish obligation, permission and prediction from inference, and resolve modal ambiguity through context and paraphrase.

What deontic and epistemic modality communicates

Distinguish obligation, permission and prediction from inference, and resolve modal ambiguity through context and paraphrase.

The central purpose is to show whether a modal concerns how the world is known or how people are required to act. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The documents must remain confidential.	an obligation governing behaviour or state
The documents must already be in the archive.	a strong conclusion based on evidence
A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.	a general potential arising from circumstances or properties

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: modal + proposition interpreted through source, time and agency. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The documents must remain confidential, and they must already be in the archive.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Deontic necessity	must + controllable action	The documents must remain confidential.
Epistemic necessity	must + state/perfect inference	The documents must already be in the archive.
Dynamic potential	can + subject capacity/characteristic	A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
an obligation governing behaviour or state	Deontic necessity
a strong conclusion based on evidence	Epistemic necessity
a general potential arising from circumstances or properties	Dynamic potential

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in policy, legal reasoning, analysis and nuanced conversation. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02
modal	proposition interpreted through source, time and agency

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: show whether a modal concerns how the world is known or how people are required to act.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits policy, legal reasoning, analysis and nuanced conversation.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Deontic necessity	must + controllable action	The documents must remain confidential.
Epistemic necessity	must + state/perfect inference	The documents must already be in the archive.
Dynamic potential	can + subject capacity/characteristic	A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The documents must remain confidential.	an obligation governing behaviour or state
The documents must already be in the archive.	a strong conclusion based on evidence
A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.	a general potential arising from circumstances or properties

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not read every must as a logical deduction.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not paraphrase epistemic must as an imposed rule.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not confuse general dynamic possibility with permission.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an obligation governing behaviour or state?

OPTIONS The documents must remain confidential. · The documents must already be in the archive. · A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a strong conclusion based on evidence?

OPTIONS The documents must already be in the archive. · A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown. · The documents must remain confidential.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a general potential arising from circumstances or properties?

OPTIONS A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown. · The documents must remain confidential. · The documents must already be in the archive.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The documents must remain confidential.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an obligation governing behaviour or state · a strong conclusion based on evidence · a general potential arising from circumstances or properties

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The documents must already be in the archive.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a strong conclusion based on evidence · a general potential arising from circumstances or properties · an obligation governing behaviour or state

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a general potential arising from circumstances or properties · an obligation governing behaviour or state · a strong conclusion based on evidence

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“The documents must remain confidential.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Deontic necessity / Epistemic necessity / Dynamic potential · Gap 2: an obligation governing behaviour or state / a strong conclusion based on evidence / a general potential arising from circumstances or properties

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“The documents must already be in the archive.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Epistemic necessity / Dynamic potential / Deontic necessity · Gap 2: a strong conclusion based on evidence / a general potential arising from circumstances or properties / an obligation governing behaviour or state

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Dynamic potential / Deontic necessity / Epistemic necessity · Gap 2: a general potential arising from circumstances or properties / an obligation governing behaviour or state / a strong conclusion based on evidence

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses an obligation governing behaviour or state: _____. Choose the model that expresses a strong conclusion based on evidence: _____. Choose the model that expresses a general potential arising from circumstances or properties: _____. Choose the model built with must + controllable action: _____. Choose the model built with must + state/perfect inference: _____. Choose the model built with can + subject capacity/characteristic: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown. · The documents must already be in the archive. · The documents must remain confidential.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The documents _____. The documents _____ in the archive. A minor configuration error _____ a complete shutdown. State the full structural pattern for Deontic necessity: _____. State the full structural pattern for Epistemic necessity: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

05 · PRACTICE STAGE

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The rules require confidentiality.” using the Deontic necessity pattern to express an obligation governing behaviour or state.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The evidence strongly indicates the documents are archived.” using the Epistemic necessity pattern to express a strong conclusion based on evidence.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Such an error is capable of causing shutdown.” using the Dynamic potential pattern to express a general potential arising from circumstances or properties.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The rules require confidentiality.” using the Deontic necessity pattern to express an obligation governing behaviour or state.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Deontic necessity to express an obligation governing behaviour or state, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Epistemic necessity to express a strong conclusion based on evidence, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Dynamic potential to express a general potential arising from circumstances or properties, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The documents must remain confidential.

Deontic necessity is the best match because an obligation governing behaviour or state.

A2

The documents must already be in the archive.

Epistemic necessity is the best match because a strong conclusion based on evidence.

A3

A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.

Dynamic potential is the best match because a general potential arising from circumstances or properties.

A4

an obligation governing behaviour or state

The Deontic necessity pattern communicates an obligation governing behaviour or state.

A5

a strong conclusion based on evidence

The Epistemic necessity pattern communicates a strong conclusion based on evidence.

A6

a general potential arising from circumstances or properties

The Dynamic potential pattern communicates a general potential arising from circumstances or properties.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Deontic necessity / an obligation governing behaviour or state

The structure belongs to the Deontic necessity pattern. Its communicative purpose is an obligation governing behaviour or state.

B2

Epistemic necessity / a strong conclusion based on evidence

The structure belongs to the Epistemic necessity pattern. Its communicative purpose is a strong conclusion based on evidence.

B3

Dynamic potential / a general potential arising from circumstances or properties

The structure belongs to the Dynamic potential pattern. Its communicative purpose is a general potential arising from circumstances or properties.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The documents must remain confidential.

Deontic necessity: must + controllable action.

C2

The documents must already be in the archive.

Epistemic necessity: must + state/perfect inference.

C3

A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.

Dynamic potential: can + subject capacity/characteristic.

C4

The documents must remain confidential.

Deontic necessity: must + controllable action.

C5

The documents must already be in the archive.

Epistemic necessity: must + state/perfect inference.

C6

A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.

Dynamic potential: can + subject capacity/characteristic.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

must remain confidential

Deontic necessity requires “must remain confidential” in this model. must + controllable action.

D2

must already be

Epistemic necessity requires “must already be” in this model. must + state/perfect inference.

D3

can cause

Dynamic potential requires “can cause” in this model. can + subject capacity/characteristic.

D4

must + controllable action

Deontic necessity is built as must + controllable action.

D5

must + state/perfect inference

Epistemic necessity is built as must + state/perfect inference.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The documents must remain confidential.

must + controllable action. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended deontic necessity effect.

E2

The documents must already be in the archive.

must + state/perfect inference. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended epistemic necessity effect.

E3

A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown.

can + subject capacity/characteristic. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended dynamic potential effect.

E4

The documents must remain confidential.

must + controllable action. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended deontic necessity effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The documents must remain confidential. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses must + controllable action accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The documents must already be in the archive. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses must + state/perfect inference accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

A minor configuration error can cause a complete shutdown. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses can + subject capacity/characteristic accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____